

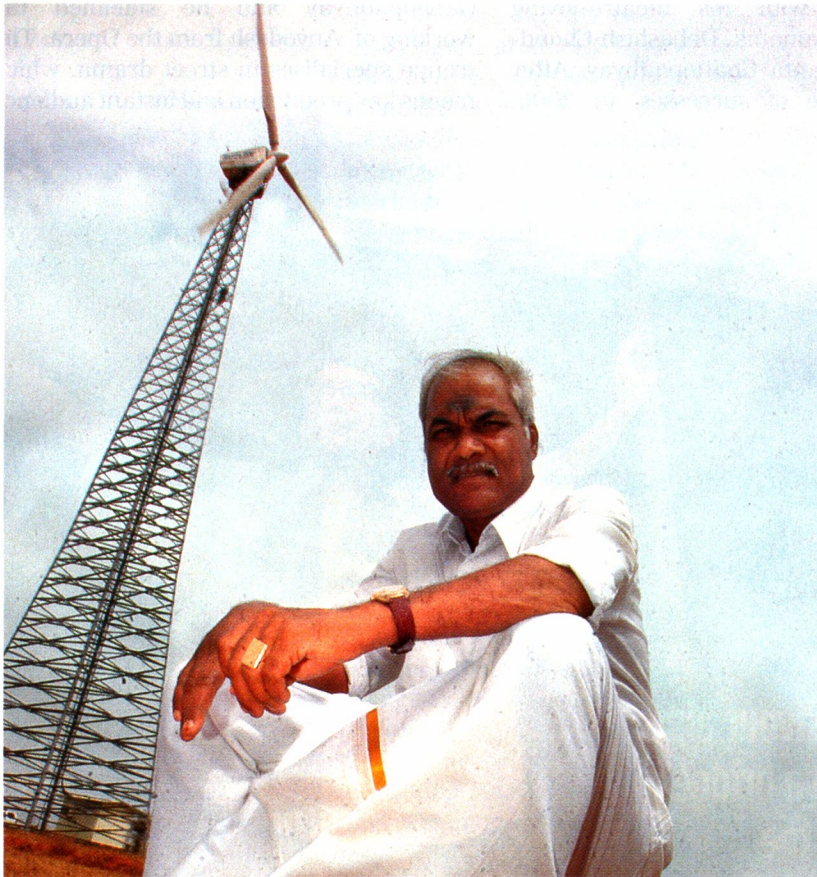
winds of CHANGE

✱ **R. Shanmugam, 52**

Project Creating
self-sufficiency
in energy

Can-do Icon Dr A.P.J.
Abdul Kalam, because he
helped sow the seeds of
confidence in rural India

40 per cent
of the population in
India still doesn't
have electricity



H K RAJASHEKAR

The first local body in the country to build its own 350-MW windmill, the first to have a community water-supply scheme, the first to install biomass gasifiers to generate power.

These are just some of the many firsts that Odanthurai, 40 km north of Coimbatore, has
clocked up over the years. And the man responsible for it all? R. Shanmugam. When he

took up the reins of Odanthurai panchayat, consisting of 11 villages with a total population of 5,000, as its president 10 years ago, he was setting aside 60 per cent of its budget to pay electricity charges, leaving just 40 per cent to be spent on the area's own development.

Troubled by this state of affairs, the resourceful panchayat head formed a plan to reduce electricity expenses by having the panchayat generate its own power. The first steps in creating an energy self-sufficient future for Odanthurai were taken with the erection of solar streetlights in all the villages. He followed this with the setting up of biomass gasifiers to generate power from the waste of Odanthurai's saw mill. Explains Shanmugam, "A 9-KW capacity biomass gasifier uses 11 kg of wood waste to generate six units of electricity per hour. The price of wood waste is Re 1 per kg and so, by spending Rs 11, we are producing six units of electricity in an hour."

The next step in his programme was the use of windmills to generate energy, with the first one starting operations in March 2006. In a situation where other parts of the state are complaining about power cuts, Odanthurai is now enjoying surplus power. "While we generate 8 lakh units of electricity annually, the need of the panchayat alone is 4.5 lakh units. The rest ends up getting sold to the electricity board and the additional income from the sale can be utilised for the development of the panchayat," says Shanmugam.

Together with his wife, S. Lingammal, who is now the panchayat president, Shanmugam used the success of the generation programme as a launchpad to raise the standard of living in Odanthurai. The panchayat now has pucca roads, potable water and streetlights. "With three primary and high schools, Odanthurai is free of child labour and dropouts," says Shanmugam. "There are also no families living below the poverty line here." And his plans for the future? "I want to introduce my people to the luxuries of life, starting with the car. Given his track record, you can bet on it."

by Banumathi Krishnaswamy

**If we work honestly and keep the goal of public service
in mind, nothing is impossible.**

R. SHANMUGAM, Former president, Odanthurai panchayat